

Dissertations

Outline

1. Overall expectations
2. Different types of research question
3. Different types of research design
4. Timeline (still preliminary for 2025-26)

Overall expectations

- What are we looking for? (in general)
 - Your ability to conduct a piece of independent research.
 - Your ability to sustain and develop your own argument over an extended (article-length) piece of research.
 - Your ability to show how you have learned from your studies in public policy and administration.
 - Good presentational practice (introduction, structure, referencing, tables).

Overall expectations

- What are we looking for? (in particular)
 - Clear argument (or clear hypotheses)
 - A good argument/hypothesis is one that *could potentially be “proved” right or wrong on the basis of evidence* (even if your evidence can only partially do this).
 - Original empirical analysis
 - IMPORTANT: empirical does **NOT** necessarily mean quantitative
 - Link to broader theoretical relevance
 - “Of what is this an instance?”
 - Why should anyone else be interested in your research?
 - Bonus for things like: originality, importance, difficulty

Overall expectations

- What are we NOT looking for:
 - A description of a policy area or policy problem.
 - A normative evaluation of a policy.
 - A proposal for what policymakers ought to do.
 - A prospective analysis of something that hasn't happened yet.
 - A policy evaluation ("did it work?") without theoretical relevance.

Different types of research question

$$x \rightarrow y$$

- “y-centered” questions
 - Explaining a puzzle; “causes of effects”
 - “Puzzle”: An (arguably) unexpected event or non-event; or an intriguing difference across cases.
 - Either actual variation (across cases) or implied variation (single case)
- “x-centered” questions
 - The impact of something on something else; “effects of causes”
- Incorporating some of each:
 - What theory or interpretation best characterizes a phenomena?

Different types of research question

- Avoid mere descriptions of events or policy areas, without the structure of clear research question with distinct potential answers.
- A good research question points towards the types of possible answers:
 - ✓ “Why did A happen in this case (, but B happen in another case)?” → explanations
 - ✓ “What was the effect of X on Y?” → impacts
 - ✓ “Is phenomena X better understood with theoretical approach A, B, or C?”
 - ✗ “What should policymakers do about X” → not empirical (unless comparing effectiveness of multiple existing approaches with x-centered questions)
 - ✗ “How does X play a role in Y?” → unclear unless theory provides contrasting answers
 - ✗ “How did X happen?” → purely descriptive unless clearly structured with competing hypotheses/explanations
 - ✗ “Why did X happen *and* what were its consequences?” → too much for one diss.!

Different types of research question

- A frequent situation: “I’m interested in [some policy/process/event] but don’t know what makes sense as an empirical research question!”
- Some first-order options to consider:
 - y-centered:
 - Why did this happen?
 - Why did it happen in case A but not in case B? (remember, “case” can be interpreted broadly)
 - Why did it happen in form A rather than in form B?
 - Why did the way that it happened vary from setting to setting?
 - x-centered:
 - What effect did it have on Y?
 - How did the effects that it had depend on intervening factor Z?
 - More complex:
 - Do theoretical approaches / conceptual apparatus A or B better help us understand how it works / how it happened / how individuals acted, etc.

Different types of research design

- Single case study
- Comparative case studies
- Quantitative study
- Survey-based study

Different types of research design

Single case study

- Can be a case of a policy, institution, episode, process, etc.
- Need to establish how the case is “puzzling;” or offers particular theoretical insight/importance.
 - E.g. because theory says it should not be like this; theory ignores this; theory is contentious; etc.
- Prerequisite: can you get beyond superficial information?
 - Access to people, documents, language, archives
- Common issues:
 - What is it a case of?
 - Ensuring evidence speaks to testing hypotheses/arguments, going beyond just description.
 - Sufficient access, language skills, understanding of context?

Different types of research design

Comparative case studies

- “Classic” two-country comparison (but need to establish comparability)
 - Sometimes three countries; more than that gets risky. Depth vs breadth.
- Within-country comparison (e.g. organizations, subnational units)
- Comparison over time (before-vs-after); across policy areas; or even across multiple instances of a specific dynamic.
- Ameliorates some burden of access: Compare on basis of publicly available data.
- Still need to establish why puzzling and/or important to study.
- Common issues: Differences obvious, or not as strong as supposed? Comparability? What does the comparison show you that you cannot get from a case study?

Different types of research design

Quantitative study

- Regression model, or sometimes “light” quant based on targeted descriptive stats.
- If you have data or can generate a dataset.
- Testing explanatory hypotheses or evaluating impact of one key indep var.
- Not likely possible to reach frontier of methodological sophistication, but must at least be able to speak to most obvious concerns (e.g. causality)
- Still requires theoretical grounding to generate expectations/hypotheses.
- Common issues:
 - Has it been done before? Do you have necessary technical skills? Do measures adequately capture concepts? Clarity of presentation?
- Not a problem: Null results (provided your study is well-designed)

Different types of research design

Survey-based study

- Usually focused on variation across individuals; or in individuals across different settings.
 - More rarely, focused on interpretation of qualitative responses.
 - Could also consider survey experiments with randomised vignettes.
- Must go beyond simply “what do people think about this?”
- Common issues
 - Questionnaire design; sample design; response rate; sample size.
 - Need ethics review approval.

A few example research questions

- What explains differences across (three countries in the same region) in the extent to which politicians promoted (specific policy innovation)?
 - Y-centered; qualitative comparative case studies.
- What is the effect of (specific administrative change)(in specific sector in specific country) on PSM?
 - X-centered; quantitative survey of individuals across different settings.
- Does representation of women in police forces lead to changes in public behaviour or org. performance (in a specific country)?
 - X-centered; medium-N comparison across ~20 entities, both qual and quant.
- Why did policymakers in (a specific country) pay so much attention to international rankings?
 - Y-centered; qualitative single case study.
- What is the effect of fiscal decentralization on service delivery in (a specific country)?
 - X-centered; quantitative regression analysis of subnational units.
- Why is (specific policy area) in (specific country) so much less captured by industry than in other similar settings?
 - Y-centered; single case but motivated by cross-case variation.
- Which legislative proposals in (a specific country) get on the agenda to receive debate?
 - Y-centered; interviews and light quant.
- What is the effect of ministerial reorganization on policy collaboration (in a specific country & policy area)?
 - X-centered; qualitative comparison before/after plus policymaker survey focused on open-ended responses.

Preliminary 2026 timeline (not yet final)

- 20 February 2026:
 - Dissertation supervisor request form. Brief outline of topic and possible research questions.
- 27 February 2026:
 - Allocation of dissertation supervisors. (*This is **not** up to the supervisor themselves!*)
- 30 March 2026:
 - Deadline for submission of dissertation prospectus of around 1000 words.
- 15 May 2026:
 - Deadline for Dissertation Topic Approval Form.
- 19 June 2026:
 - End of formal dissertation supervision.
- 23 June – 31 July 2026:
 - Supervisors run two dissertation support windows. Additional support available through LSE Life, Methodology department, Government department.
- 18 August 2024:
 - Dissertation submission deadline

Other notes

- PPA relevance: Is any key concept (e.g. IV/DV) relevant to the decisionmaking, design, implementation, evaluation, or administration of any public policy?
- Beware difficulty of studying something that hasn't happened yet.
- Absolutely OK to base topic on expertise you already have (or want to gain) and/or where you expect to be during summer.
- Ethics review (if research will involve human subjects e.g. interviews or surveys)
- Dissertation supervisor is not your manager; they are there for advice/guidance.
- See MSc PPA examples on GV499 Moodle page (but don't treat them as too prescriptive)
- Some useful resources:
 - Booth *Craft of Research* (a broad introduction to how to think about structuring research and setting out arguments, written for arts and humanities, natural and social sciences)
 - Gerring *Social Science Methodology: A Unified Framework* (useful research methodology primer)